"The idea really began at the Azim Premji Foundation, with whom I have been associated for about two and a half years, scoring music for their podcasts. They focus on promoting constitutional values like unity, equality and social justice. The Vachanas, which were part of the Bhakti movement, resonate deeply with these principles," he shares. "For our Thermal And A Quarter projects, we have always tried to create socially relevant music, so this collaboration felt like a natural extension of that."

What began as an improvised jam session for a university podcast soon evolved into a full-fledged musical project. "Pallavi and I just sat in a seminar hall, put two mics, and recorded her singing while I accompanied her on the acoustic guitar. It was spontaneous—and it just clicked," he recalls. "That initial jam turned into something bigger and just kept growing. Now, it has evolved into a project that we both really believe in, and we even have our own band."

Blending ancient poetry with modern sound has been both organic and experimental for the two artistes. As Bruce points out, "Pallavi comes from a Hindustani classical and folk background, while I come from rock, blues and jazz. When our worlds meet, something different happens—the sound naturally becomes something fresh and hybrid—not pure classical, not rock, but a fusion of both our journeys."

KAYAKAVE KAILASA features eight tracks—four full-band and three acoustic—with about 60 minutes performed live

Reflecting on why these centuries-old voices matter today, Bruce says, "We are living in strange times—the pace of change is dizzying, and not always for the better. Power seems to be concentrated in fewer and fewer hands, and that's worrying. Compassionate, honest and kind voices feel necessary again. The Vachanas reflect that—they remind us of equality, compassion and justice."

Kayaka's album *Kayakave Kailasa* launched on October 31 at the Indian Heritage Academy, Bengaluru, and a digital release will follow later this year. The album currently features eight tracks—four full-band and three acoustic—with about 60 minutes performed live. "We're not chasing grand outcomes. We're just enjoying the process—and if our work moves someone along the way, that's more than enough," says Bruce. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo



▼ **NOV. 16 |** The Grand Theatre, NMACC, **MUMBAI**

TONY ANN LIVE

Global piano sensation Tony Ann brings his extraordinary artistry to India for one night only. Famed for his viral performances and innovative compositions, the Canadian-born pianist fuses emotion, technique and storytelling in a way that transcends genre. With over a billion online views and sold-out concerts worldwide, Tony Ann reimagines classical music for a new generation.

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NCPA INTERNATIONAL JAZZ FESTIVAL 2025

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—Compiled by Nikhil Sardana